

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

15 January 2010

To an individual Bahá'í

1 Dear Bahá'í Friend,

2 Your email letter of 11 October 2009, concerning Bahá'í law as regards marrying one's relatives, has been received by the Universal House of Justice. We have been asked to convey the following in response.

3 The House of Justice has clearly stated that it is not permissible for a Bahá'í to marry his or her mother or father and their siblings and forebears, brothers or sisters and their descendents, or sons or daughters and their descendents. It is also not permissible to marry some corresponding categories of relations formed by bonds of marriage—such as the step-mother, step-father, step-daughter, or step-son, or the daughter-in-law, son-in-law, mother-in-law, or father-in-law—or similar categories of relations formed by legal and social bonds that create a shared family life, for example through adoption. Beyond these prohibitions, Bahá'ís should ensure they do not contract a marriage that would violate the customs or laws of the country in which they reside. While the House of Justice has refrained, at this stage, from defining other categories of relations with whom marriage is prohibited, it is important for believers everywhere to be mindful of this clear statement by the Master:

4 In marriage the more distant the blood-relationship the better, for such distance in family ties between husband and wife provideth the basis for the well-being of humanity and is conducive to fellowship among mankind.

5 It is hoped that the foregoing provides the clarification you seek. You are assured of the prayers of the House of Justice in the Holy Shrines on your behalf.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]